

Seams: Open, French, overlaid, and double stitched seams

Types of seams

Two major types of seams in garment construction are: -

- 1) **Structural seams** - These join major garment sections together e.g. shoulder seams and side seams. These seams are visible inside the garment.
- 2) **Enclosed seams** - These finish the perimeters of collars, cuffs and other faced sections. Their seam allowances are sandwiched between fabric sections and are completely hidden from view.

Structural Seams

- Accurate stitching of structural seams is crucial to the development of the garment.
- Structural seams are visible from within an unlined garment. Hence they are subject to friction as the seams rub against the body.
- Fraying may result if the seams are left unfinished.
- To protect these seams, the seam allowances should remain untrimmed and raw edges or enclosed seam finish applied.
- A curved seam however, must be clipped to enable it to lie flat when the seam is pressed open after stitching.
- Structural seams directly control the fit, silhouette, and styling of the garment.

General Construction Procedures of Seams

- To ensure accurate seam line location, garment fit should be checked and corrected prior to stitching.
- Other stitching problems can be avoided by test-checking needle size, thread type, stitch length, and machine tension using swatches of fabric.
- Seam allowances on commercial patterns are usually 1.5 cm (5/8") wide.
- In some cases they may be 1 cm (3/8") or 6 mm (1/4")
- The edges of structural seams may be finished or special seams may be used to enclose the raw edges to eliminate friction.

General Pressing Procedures of Seams

These procedures may be adapted to various seam types.

- 1) Press the seam flat (as stitched) to blend the stitches and to reduce thread tautness. Making it easier to press the seam open.
- 2) With the fabric sections spread apart and the seam allowances top, use the tip of the iron to separate and press them open.

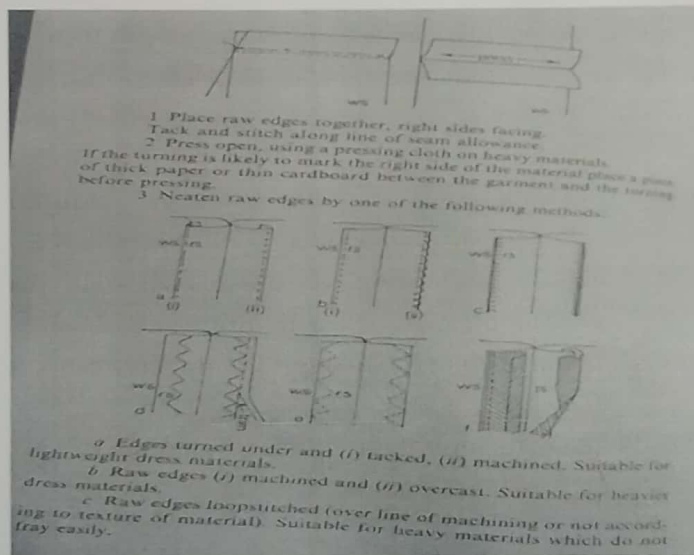
Straight Seams

1) Plain seams

Plain seams are basic straight seams used to hold the garment together in areas such as centre front or back, at the shoulder, or at the sides. They relate to the garment body contours by their angle to the lengthwise grain of fabric.

Procedure

- i) With right sides together and cut edges even, pin fabric layers together.
 - Align match-stitching lines at seam ends, match corresponding notches and insert pins through any corresponding dots.
 - Insert the pins at right angles to the seam line about 7.5 – 10 cm (3-4") apart.
- ii) Tack and permanently stitch along the seam line through all layers of fabric.

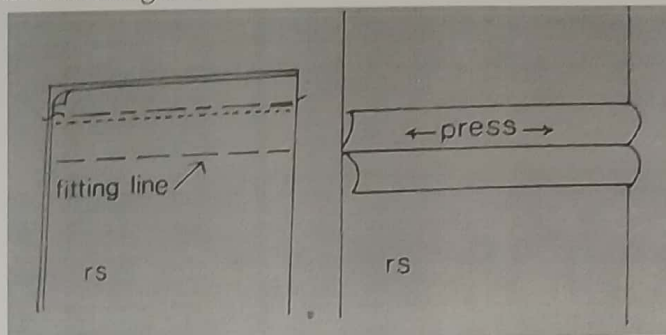


2) French seam

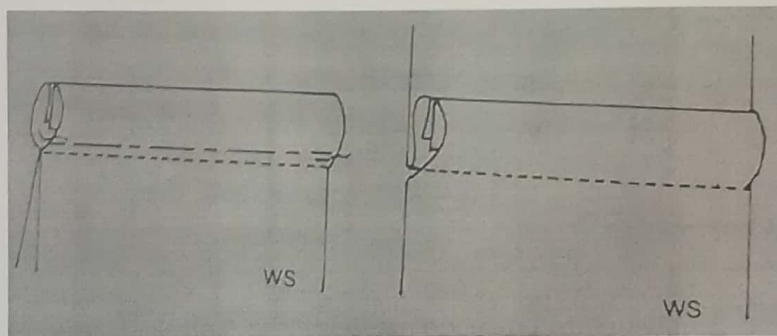
This is a useful seam for underwear, nightdresses, children's dresses, blouses and most straight seams on thin fabrics. Raw edges of the seam are enclosed hence they are not visible when the seam is complete and no stitching shows on the right side of work. The seam should be pressed towards the back of garment when complete.

Procedure

- i. With wrong sides facing, place raw edges together. Tack and stitch 6mm outside the stitching line.



- ii. Remove tacking, press the seam open and trim to 4mm.
- iii. Fold along stitched line with right sides together, carefully pressing out the stitching between fingers.
- iv. Tack 6mm from the edge and completely enclose the raw edges. Stitch on the seam allowance below the tacking line.



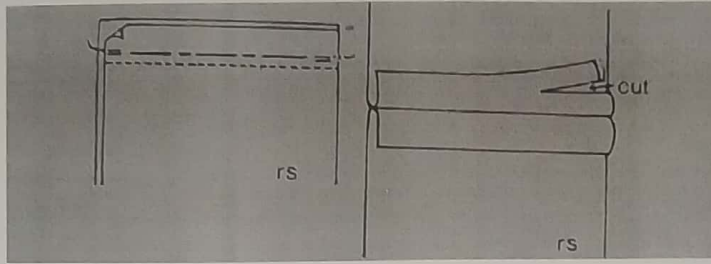
- v. Remove tacking and press the seam towards the back of garment.

3) **Double stitched seam**

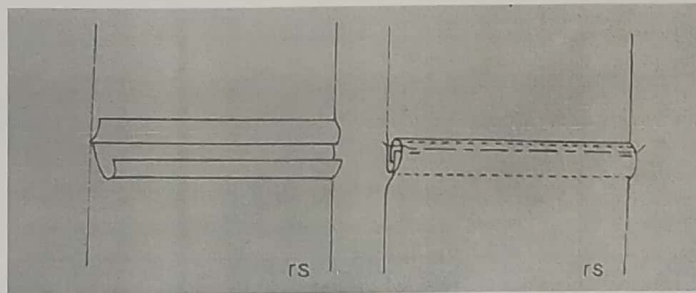
This is sometimes referred to as 'machine fell' seam. The seam is suitable for thick and fine lingerie fabrics and is particularly useful in making pyjamas, and panties where a curved seam is required.

Procedure

- i. Place raw edges together with wrong sides facing. Tack and stitch on the seam allowance.



- ii. Remove tackings and press the seam open. Cut down half the depth of back turning of one side of the seam.
- iii. Make 5mm turning on the front free edge.



- iv. Turn the fold towards back of garment ensuring that the raw edge is underneath the turning. Tack, stitch close to the edge and remove tacking.
- v. Press the seam flat.

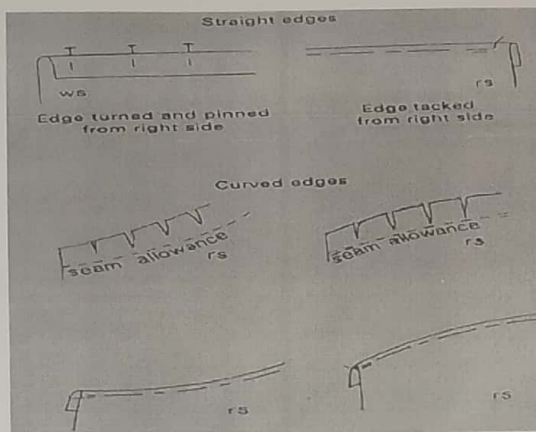
4) Overlaid seam

This is the most useful seam for outer and undergarments. It is a strong seam if adequate turnings are provided.

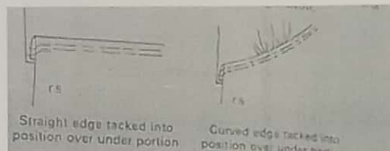
Procedure

- i. Turn the the depth of the seam allowance of edge be overlaid to the wrong side (for a staight seam).

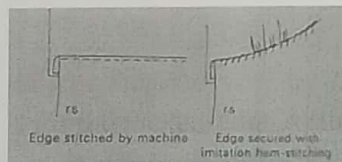
If a curved line is required, he edge must be snipped at intervals before being turned. Tack on the edge of the fold.



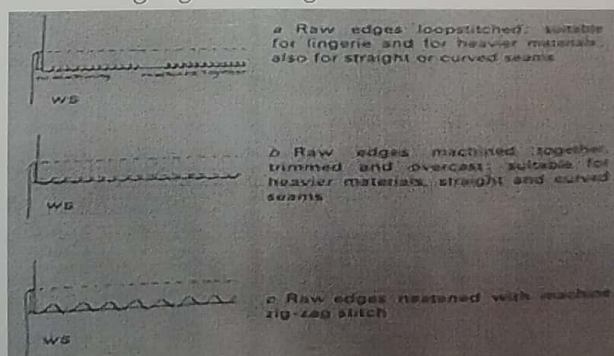
- ii. Place the tacked edge to the seam line of the under portion of the garment, right sides uppermost and tack in position.



- iii. Edge stitch on the seam line securing all thicknesses by machine or hem-stitching.



- iv. Neaten raw edges by any ideal method such as loopstitching, overcasting or machine zigzag stitching.

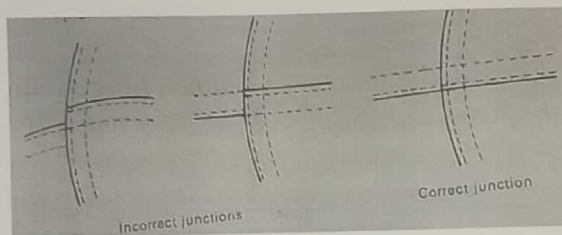


5) Intersecting Seams

- Often two seams from different garment units are joined by a third seam e.g. shirt side seam and sleeve underarm seam are joined by the armcye seam.
- Special techniques must be used to align the seam precisely at the point of intersection.

Procedure

- i) Insert a pin through the seam line intersections of each garment section. Match, pin and stitch the seam.
- ii) To reduce the bulk created by the seam allowances at the intersection, trim the four corners of the seam allowances diagonally.



6) Bias Seams

- Garment sections cut on the true bias exhibit some degree of stretch and as a result, cling more closely to the body than those cut following the lengthwise grain.
- This gives a desirable characteristic of the bias cut which can be destroyed by incorrect seaming.
- If the seam is free-falling, as in a skirt, stitch only the upper 7.5 cm (3").
- Allow the garment to hang until the fabric sections have stretched (about 24 hours).
- Pin the seams as they hand; stitch, stretching them slightly.
- Stitch shorter structural seams, stretching them slightly as they are stitched.